

switching channels or surfing the Internet, via the Internet Explorer 5.5 browser. Both peripherals are washable.

Gateway Media Center 610

The 610 Media Center is an all-in-one PC, TV, DVD, PVR, MP3 player, FM tuner and stereo system that requires only two cables to get up and get going; a digital home entertainment system at its simplest. The 610 features the Microsoft XP Media Center OS 2004 and an Intel Pentium 4 processor with wireless technology.



Personal Video Recorder capabilities let you pause and rewind live TV and record shows with the press of a button. You can listen to your favourite tunes—Gateway also throws in a month of free Napster service; watch movies, view photo albums and slide-shows, listen to FM radio stations, or play games—all from one location, and with the convenience of a single remote control. A 17-inch wide-screen LCD with a built-in subwoofer adds both visual and sonic punch to the package.

Recently unveiled, the Gateway 901 Family Room Media Center PC is similar to its brethren with one major difference: its form factor lets it sit on a rack with stereo equipment.

CommanderPack

Here's one device that takes convergence to the extreme and packs it all into an easy-to-carry backpack. The CommanderPack straps on to your back and comes with a cell phone, a two-way radio, a Tablet PC, a satellite link, a helmet with a built-in video camera, microphone, and a special waterproof glove that can be used to make phone calls, send e-mail, or transmit video.

The cell phone, radio and satellite link



provide integrated local and worldwide connectivity from land, sea or air for voice, data and video communications. It has a GPS locator for tracking and mapping services along with weather forecasting, e-mail messaging, video conferencing and wireless LAN capabilities. The Tablet PC can, obviously, handle office applications and information management.

Aquos LC-151U-S

The Aquos LC-151U-S is weird TV. Introduced in September, the unit from Sharp offers a unique take on wireless networking: its 15-inch LCD detaches from the base, and one can use the built-in handle to take it places. The unit is battery-powered, connects via 802.11b wireless to its base station, which in turn transmits content from a video source to the set. This



way you can watch movies or TV in any room while the base remains connected to the source of the video.

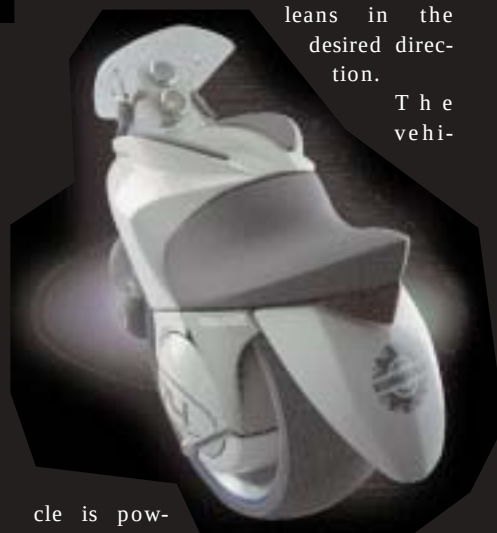
EMBRIO

A personal recreational vehicle. With just one wheel, the EMBRIO looks like a joke, but take a closer look at the design and the technology behind the enigma, and

one can only come away impressed. Gyroscopic and electronic magic make up for the solitary wheel, along with sensors, a high-performance braking system, an active suspension, night vision and robotic assistance.

A concept vehicle, a digitally encoded learning key will start the engine. To move forward, the rider activates a trigger on the left handlebar. A landing gear that offers additional balance at slow speeds retracts when the speed reaches 20 Km/h. To turn, the rider leans in the desired direction.

The vehicle



is powered by a fuel cell, and recycled aluminum and polyethylene for the body makes the Bombardier EMBRIO an eco-friendly design.

The technological reasons for the flood of convergence devices are plenty: fabrication processes for electronic components are improving at a healthy rate, bringing along smaller, more energy efficient processors and circuit boards to go along. Take LCDs then, they are now cheaper to manufacture and offer great clarity. Hard disks are shrinking with burgeoning capacities in tow; rechargeable batteries are coming to the fore (with fuel cells on the way), things are generally looking good for us.

Convergence is no longer a catchphrase that is juggled around within social circles and at boring parties. The concept has emerged from the drawing board of technology and the demand of economics has brought it within buying distance of us consumers. 

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